

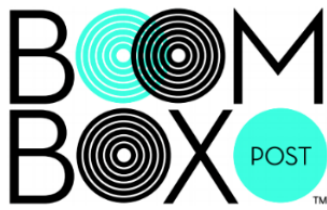
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CREATING THE SOUND OF A FUTURISTIC SPACECRAFT ENGINE



WRITTEN BY JEFF SHIFFMAN

CO-OWNER OF BOOM BOX POST



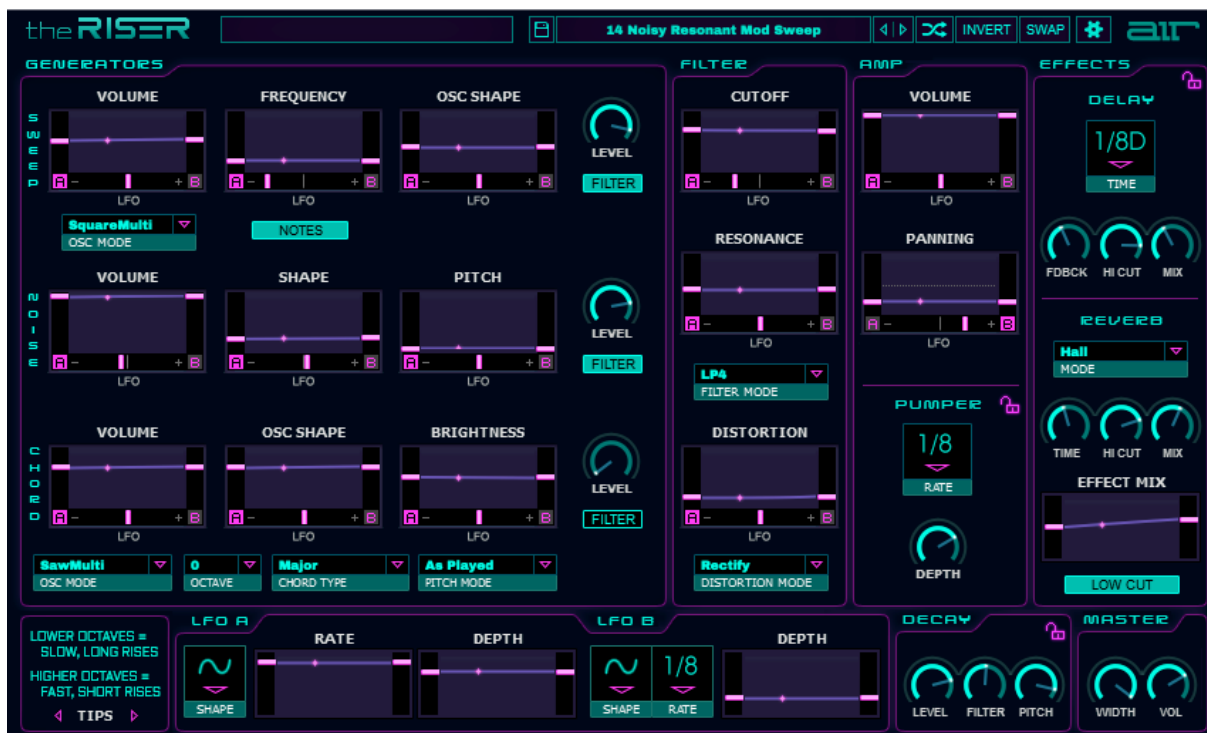
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back. My week was light so I fired up [The Riser by AIR](#). One of the presets had a really interesting oscillating sound and the functionality of The Riser made it easy for me to play around with pitch and speed. I found myself creating crazy spaceship engine sounds (very likely influenced by having just watched the movie) and thought, "this would be a great blog post!"

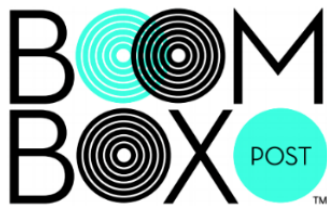
Creating futuristic *anything* is fun, but where to start? Here was my process for creating a full compliment of entirely original (and useful!) futuristic spacecraft engine sounds.

STEP 1 - A GERM OF AN IDEA

You need an anchor for your inspiration. In my case, it was this synth, The Riser. But any synth will do. Or even a funky source recording you can manipulate with pitch/time correction or software plugin processing. The goal is to find your spark and run with it. Here's the steady I created in The Riser that started this journey.

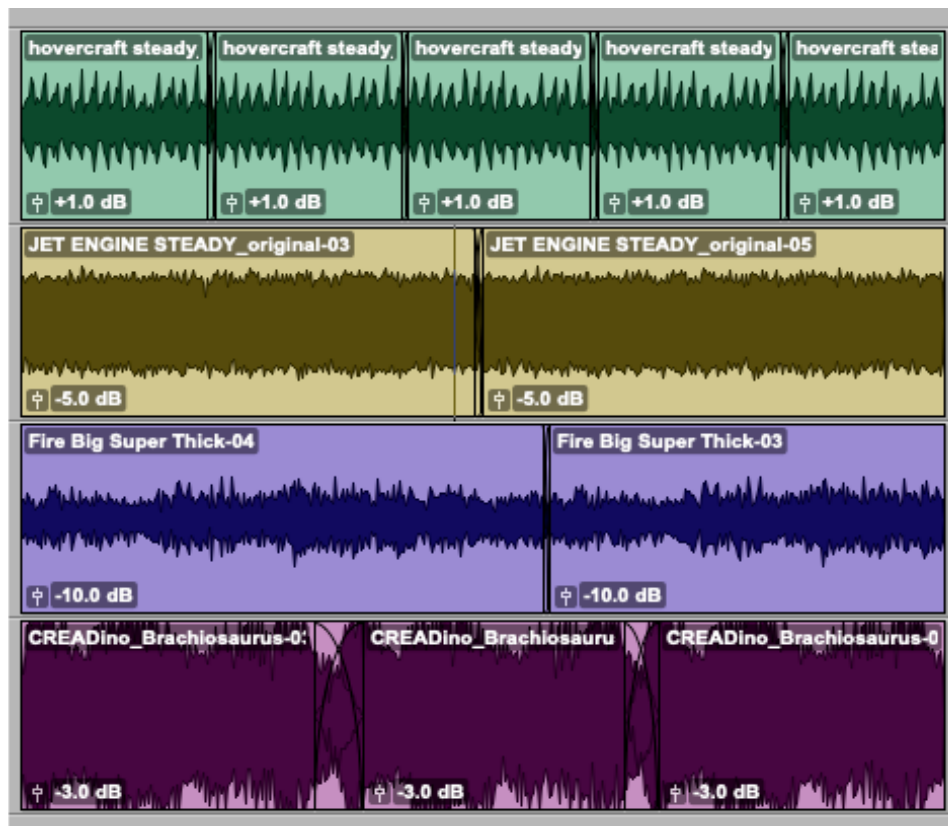


My settings in The Riser for the futuristic spacecraft synth steady



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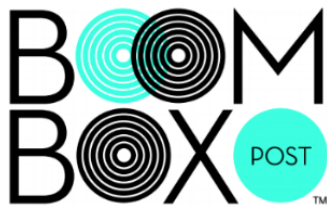
give the engine some heft, I came across some insanely cool dinosaur vocals. These had both a low frequency heft as well as some interesting texture. NOW I had my sound.



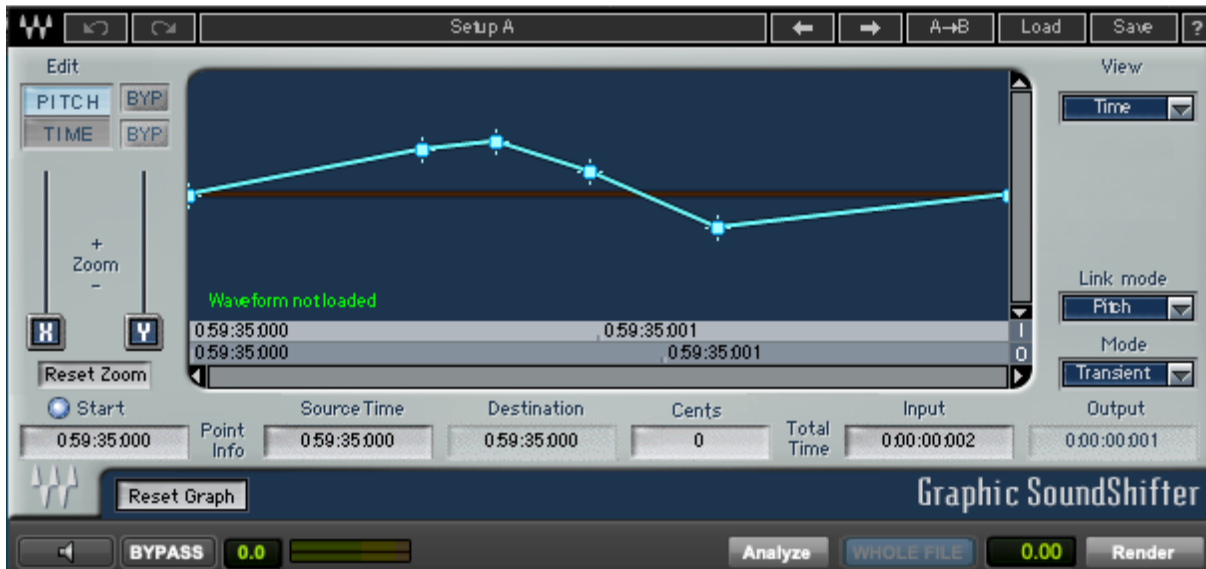
All four layers of the futuristic spacecraft engine steady

STEP 3 - HASHING IT OUT

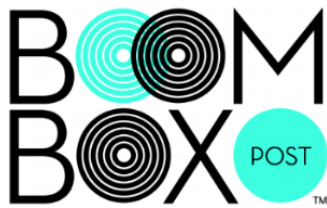
One great sound is a good start. But as I said in my post [The Basics of Vehicle Sound Design](#), *The best thing you can do for yourself is to find and collect sounds before cutting a single region. If you find a great single sound and dive in, you may spend hours trying to make it work with other sounds.* This is your



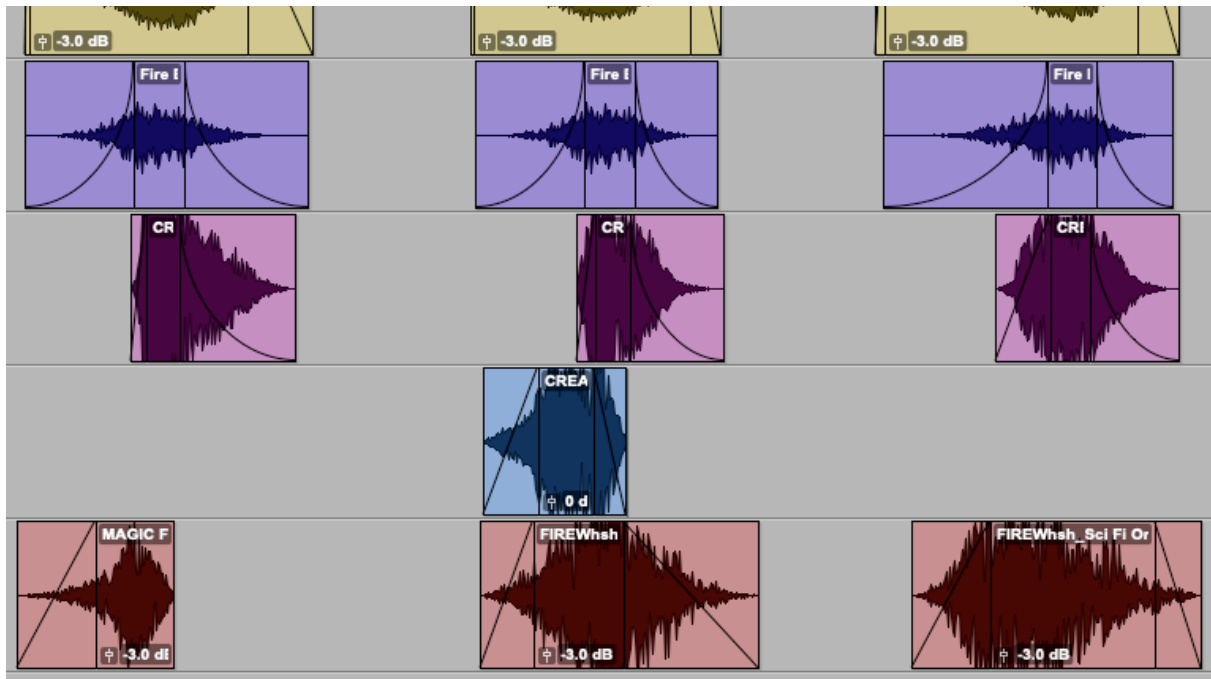
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Next up, I wanted to create some fly bys. For this functionality I like [Doppler by Waves](#). I'm able to manipulate a lot of factors with the plugin to produce a handful of great variations. I made sure to process both the original synth steady and the jet engine at the same time to ensure they matched. I then layered in some of the fire steady, some fire whooshes, and even some more crazy dinosaur vocals to give the fly bys a lot of character.



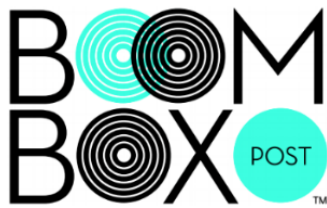
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Fly by designs in layers

As I was messing with Doppler, I pushed some of the settings to the extreme and got some wild, super-fast variations. I liked these as a whole different category which I am calling maneuvers. I pictured these sounds as being useful for U-turns, or blasting to hyperdrive. It just goes to show you, the sound design process is one of discovery. Never be so hyper focused as to ignore these happy accidents when they occur.

For the last bit of design, I wanted to create both launch and landing sequences that were a bit more unique than the flying variations I had created with pitch manipulation so I went back to The Riser. I was able to mess around with countless factors using the modulators, giving these iterations a lot of personality.



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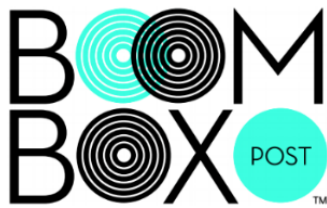


The Riser settings for the futuristic spacecraft launch, playing with pitch ramping among other factors

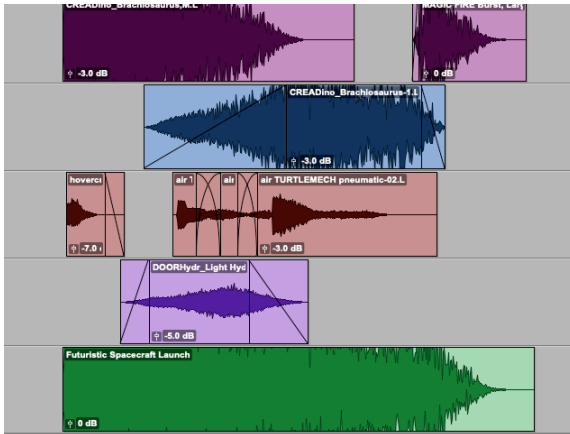
I also took the opportunity to layer in some explosions, air chuffs, fire bursts, and yes, even some more dinosaur vocals. Generally these are elements I would leave separate in my session to allow for freedom to match picture in the sound edit, but I've rendered it all together so you can hear the final results.

Sound design is a process of discovery. I hope this inspires you to take on a sound design challenge of your own. Start with an idea and run with it!

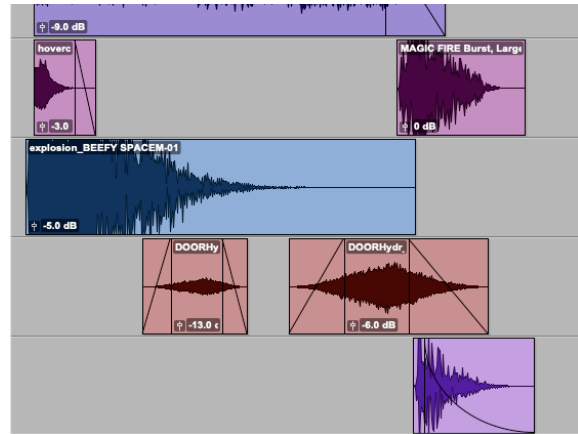
**WHAT'S UNIQUE ABOUT YOUR SOUND DESIGN PROCESS?
SHARE YOUR STORY IN THE COMMENTS.**



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Launch sequence

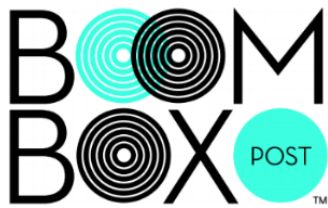


Landing sequence

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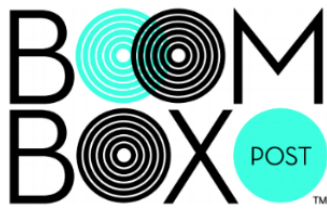
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